



APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT PRACTICES

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Introduction to Teamwork



Content

- Working Individually
- Working as a Team



Working Individually

- When you are the only one working on a project:
 - No need to gain consensus
 - No one to coordinate with
 - Don't have to explain the rationale for your decisions
 - Your decisions aren't challenged
 - Don't need to work with people you don't get along with
 - Don't need to trust anyone else to get the work done
 - Easier to hide what you are doing



Working as a Team

- You and your teammates will need to agree
- You will need to coordinate with your team
- You will need to get along with everyone on the team
- The team will need to build trust
- Your teammates may give you feedback on your performance
- You will need to develop processes, standards and conventions



Why Work in Teams?

- Today's projects are too large for individual developers to accomplish
- Software projects require a diverse set of skills and roles
- Team with synergy can produce much more than a group of individuals



Characteristics of High-Performance Teams

- A clear, elevating goal
- A results-driven structure
- Competent team members
- Unified commitment
- Collaborative climate
- Standards of excellence
- External support and recognition
- Principled leadership



Clear, Elevating Goal

- High performance teams:
 - Have a clear understanding of the goal they are trying to achieve
 - Believe the goal is significant, elevating or compelling
- Sometimes known as “A sense of mission”
- It is critical that the goal is clear to all and has specific performance objectives, so it is easy for all to know, without question, whether the goal has been met
- Personal goals can hinder team goals



Results Driven Structure

- General characteristics of effective team structure:
 - Clear roles & accountabilities
 - Effective communications
 - Key information is easily available
 - The information is credible
 - The team must have opportunities to raise any issues
 - Issues raised & decisions made must be documented
 - Monitoring individual performance & providing feedback
 - Fact based judgments



Competent Team Members

- Who on the team is critical to team success
- Decisions about who is on the team must be made in terms of who can best help the team achieve its goals
- Team member competencies:
 - Technical
 - Personal
- You want people who are committed to, and confident in, team success
 - “Nice person, wrong job”



Unified Commitment

- A sense of dedication and loyalty to the team
- A sense of excitement and enthusiasm about the team
- A willingness to sacrifice individual objectives to help the team accomplish its goals



Collaborative Climate

- A feeling or climate of trust among and between the team members:
 - Honesty
 - Integrity, no lies and no exaggeration
 - Openness
 - Willing to share
 - Receptive to information, perceptions & ideas,
 - Consistency
 - Predictable behavior & responses
 - Respect
 - Treating people with dignity & Fairness
- Trust is **EXTREMELY** fragile

Larson and LaFasto,
Teamwork



Standards of Excellence

- Pressure to achieve a required or expected level of performance can come from:
 - Individual standards
 - Team pressure
 - Consequences
 - External sources
 - The team leader
- Standards make a difference
- Standards are hard work
- Individuals need to hold each other accountable to the team's standards



External Support & Recognition

- The team is:
 - Given the resources it needs to get the job done
 - Supported by those outside of the team who are capable of aiding team success
 - Sufficiently recognized for its accomplishments
 - Perceived as being rewarded and incentivized appropriately by the team members
- Absence of external support & recognition is noticed more than its presence
- Rewards are important, but may not lead directly to team success



Principled Leadership

- A consistent message
- Unleashing talent
- A decision making climate
- Ego suppression
- Leaders create leaders



Are You a Problem?

- Covering up ignorance rather than being open to learning
- Excessive desire for privacy or territory
- Constant grumbling about old discussions and decisions
- Don't pitch in to help on team activities
- Bullying behavior
 - Sarcastic jokes, insults and teasing
 - e-mail wars
 - Rudeness, threats and intimidation



Giving and Receiving Feedback

- What is Feedback?
 - Communication that lets us know how effective we are being professionally or personally with what we are trying to accomplish or how we are affecting others

It helps us know how others perceive us



Tips for Giving Feedback

- Give positive feedback as close to the event as possible
- Praise in public, criticize in private
 - But be sure to consider what people prefer
- Praise regularly, however make sure your praise is sincere
- Make sure the praise fits
- No favorites
- Be positive, sincere and specific
- Catch people doing things right
- Cool down if things have gone poorly



Negative Styles when Giving Feedback

- Attacking: hard hitting and aggressive, focusing on the weaknesses of the other person.
- Indirect: feedback is vague and issues hinted at rather than addressed directly.
- Insensitive: little concern for the needs of the other person.
- Disrespectful: feedback is demeaning, bordering on insulting.
- Judgmental: feedback is evaluative, judging personality rather than behavior.
- General: aimed at broad issues which cannot be easily defined.
- Poor timing: given long after the event, or at the worst possible time.
- Impulsive: given thoughtlessly, with little regard for the consequences.
- Selfish: feedback meets the giver's needs, rather than the needs of the other person.
- How would you react as the receiver if this is how the speaker gives feedback?

From <http://www.selfhelpmagazine.com/articles/growth/feedback.html>



Positive Styles when Giving Feedback

- Supportive: delivered in a non-threatening and encouraging manner.
- Direct: the focus of the feedback is clearly stated.
- Sensitive: delivered with sensitivity to the needs of the other person.
- Considerate: feedback is intended to not insult or demean.
- Descriptive: focuses on behavior that can be changed, rather than personality.
- Specific: feedback is focused on specific behaviors or events.
- Healthy timing: given as close to the prompting event as possible and at an opportune time.
- Thoughtful: well considered rather than impulsive.
- Helpful: feedback is intended to be of value to the other person.
- How would you react as the receiver if this is how the speaker gives feedback?



Receiving Feedback

- How do you respond to feedback?
 - Some of us don't respond well unless all feedback is positive.
 - Some of us will react negatively (get angry, for example)
 - Some of us seek out feedback because we know it helps us grow
- Do you always accept all feedback?
 - Only friends will tell you that you have a problem
 - "Enemies" want you to fail, and will be happy to watch you make mistakes



Tips for Receiving Feedback

- Thank whoever gave you the feedback. After all, you do want them to continue to give you feedback in the future, right?
- Consider the feedback
 - You don't need to act on everything
 - You may want to prioritize feedback
 - You may want to monitor your behavior to confirm the feedback
- Over time, you may want to let whoever gave you the feedback know how valuable it was



Negative Styles when Receiving Feedback

- Defensive: defends personal actions, frequently objects to feedback given.
- Attacking: verbally attacks the feedback giver, and turns the table.
- Denies: refutes the accuracy or fairness of the feedback.
- Disrespectful: devalues the speaker, what the speaker is saying, or the speaker's right to give feedback.
- Closed: ignores the feedback, listening blankly without interest.
- Inactive listening: makes no attempt to "hear" or understand the meaning of the feedback.
- Rationalizing: finds explanations for the feedback that dissolve any personal responsibility.
- Patronizing: listens, but shows little interest.
- Superficial: listens and agrees, but gives the impression that the feedback will have little actual effect.
- How would you react as the speaker if this is how the receiver reacts?

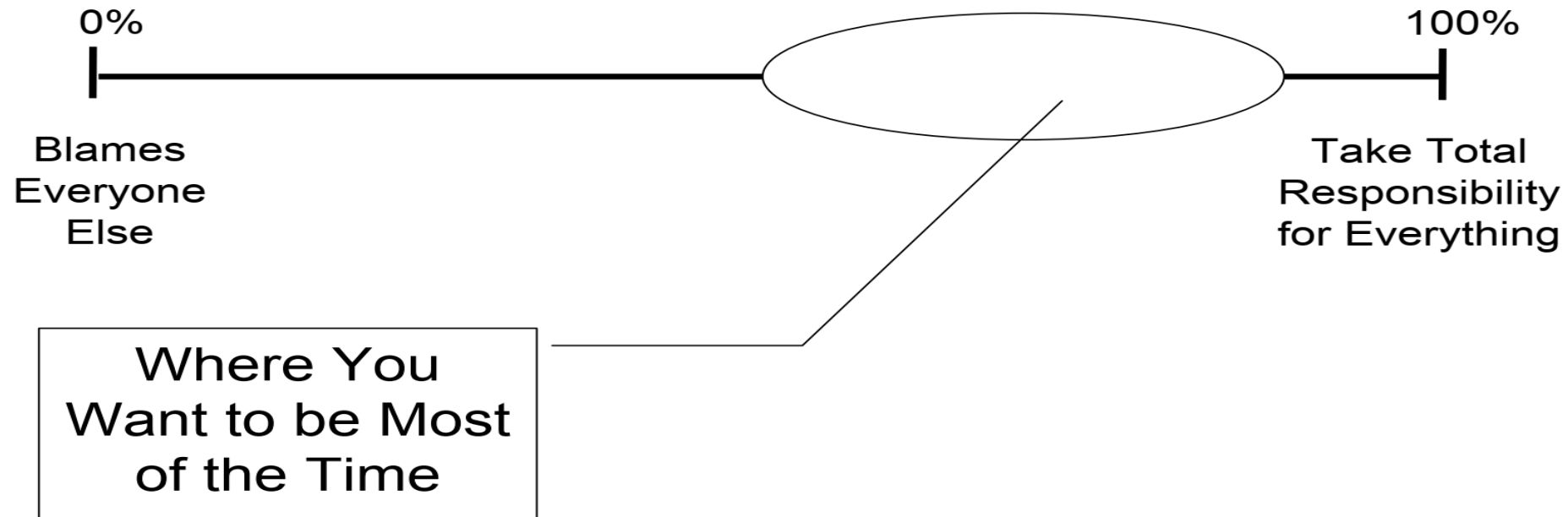


Positive Styles when Receiving Feedback

- Open: listens without frequent interruption or objections.
- Responsive: willing to hear what's being said without turning the table.
- Accepting: accepts the feedback, without denial.
- Respectful: recognizes the value of what is being said and the speaker's right to say it.
- Engaged: interacts appropriately with the speaker, asking for clarification when needed.
- Active listening: listens carefully and tries to understand the meaning of the feedback.
- Thoughtful: tries to understand the personal behavior that has led to the feedback.
- Interested: is genuinely interested in getting feedback.
- Sincere: genuinely wants to make personal changes if appropriate.
- How would you react as the speaker if this is how the receiver reacts?



Personal Responsibility





Values

- How do you know what someone's values are?
 - From their behavior

What does your behavior say about you?



Summary

- Being on a successful team is worth the effort
- Everyone is a leader, whether you think you are or not
- What does your behavior say about you?